

Phishing Attacks Explained

Phishing is one of the most common cyber-attacks in the UK, targeting individuals and businesses alike. Attackers trick people into sharing sensitive information like passwords, bank details, or personal data by pretending to be trusted sources.

These attacks rely on deception, not advanced technology. They create urgency to make you act fast without checking if the message is real.

Types of phishing

Phishing comes in different forms, each exploiting how people behave:

- Email phishing: Fake emails that look real.
- Spear phishing: Attacks aimed at specific people or jobs.
- Smishing: Phishing via text messages.
- Vishing: Phone calls trying to get your information.
- Clone phishing: Copies of real messages with hidden threats.

How phishing works

Attackers send a message with familiar logos and wording. It asks you to click a link, open an attachment, or share details. This can lead to fake websites, data theft, or malware on your device.

The impact

For individuals, phishing leads to stolen accounts, money loss, or identity theft. One breach can affect many linked services.

For businesses, it causes data leaks, fraud, downtime, and damage to reputation. Phishing often opens the door to bigger attacks.

Why it succeeds

Phishing works because it targets people, using tricks like pressure, fake identities, and convincing designs.

Warning signs

Look out for these red flags:

- Unexpected requests for private information.
- Urgent or scary words pushing quick action.
- Sender's email or phone doesn't match their claim.
- Links to odd or misspelled sites.
- Surprise attachments.
- Generic greetings like "Dear customer".

How to protect yourself

Stay safe with these simple steps:

- Check the sender before clicking or replying.
- Type website addresses directly into your browser.
- Use multi-factor authentication (MFA).
- Update your devices and apps.
- Report suspicious messages to your bank, IT team, or provider.

For businesses, add email filters, clear rules, and practice drills.

This overview helps you spot and stop phishing. Building these habits strengthens your cyber security.